

Open Networks Project

Queue Management User Guide

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SCG Workstream

DOCUMENT CONTROL

Authorities

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1 Introduction to this document.

In 2020, the Open Networks Project introduced consistency in the application of Connection Milestones across the distribution networks, publishing the ENA Open Network Project Queue Milestones User Guide¹. The Open Networks Project consulted on Connection Queue Management in July 2019² and April 2020.

In 2023, Ofgem and DESNZ published a Connections Action Plan³ to address delays in connecting projects considered crucial to achieving net zero, acknowledging the process for grid connections as not being fit for purpose and requiring fundamental reform. Ofgem and DESNZ support network company-led initiatives to reduce connection timescales, holding network companies to account to ensure delivery of the initiatives, and measures to deliver substantial further improvements.

The Connections Action Plan set out six key areas of action for Government, Ofgem, NESO and the DNOs to drive further action and significantly reduce connection timescales. Action #2 focussed on the role of Connection Milestones in the removal of stalled projects to release capacity for more viable projects. The plan required the introduction of Connection Milestones into transmission connection contracts and a review and improvement of the enforcement of Connection Milestones at distribution level. This process should therefore lead to improvements at distribution level and to improved alignment across the transmission-distribution boundary.

This document is updated to reflect the requirements of the Connections Action Plan and the broader Connections Reform work (see Section 4.2) on the overall connections process, aligning distribution with transmission where practical by:

- Defining the process of Connection Milestones for distribution projects in scope of the NESO 'Gated' process⁴ (generation connections); and
- Replacing the previous Tolerance process introduced through the Open Networks Project with a process more closely aligned with NESO's Remedy Notice.

Further clarity on the following areas is also set out to improve consistency of application of Connection Milestones by network companies, including:

- Calculation of all Connection Milestone dates from either the Offer Acceptance Date or from the Offered Connection Date depending on how far into the future the Offered Connection Date falls,
- Milestone evidence requirements and timescales,
- Application of Connection Milestones for projects built in pre-defined phases, connections with a phased increase in power requirement, and for projects for which Technical Limits and/or Curtailable connections apply, and
- Setting out a minimum threshold for the application of Connection Milestones to demand connections to the DNOs' distribution systems.

¹ [ON21-WS2-P2 Updated Queue Management User Guide \(30 Jul 2021\).pdf](#)

² The Open Networks July 2019 consultation document on Application Interactivity and Connection Queue Management is available at [2019 Consultation](#)

³ [Connections Action Plan: Speeding up connections to the electricity network across Great Britain](#)

⁴ The 'Gated' process refers to the TMO4+ code modifications for connection applications, whereby two formal gates are introduced, known as "Gate 1" and "Gate 2". Distribution projects that require a Gate 2 offer and meet clearly defined eligibility criteria will receive a confirmed connection date. For more information, see [Ofgem's Decision: Gate 2 Criteria Methodology](#)

2 What is Connection Queue Management?

Connection Queue Management is the process by which network companies manage projects that have not yet connected to their networks and are currently considered to be in the connection queue. It enables network companies to act on contracted projects if they are not progressing against the Connection Milestones, therefore minimising the impact of stalled or slow-moving projects on other projects in the relevant network's queue.

Connection Queue Management is used to provide a consistent basis on which projects are required to reach specified milestones and may also be used to remove a project from a network's connection queue where the project is delayed compared to its Connection Milestones. Where this occurs and where projects are unable to get back on-track within reasonable timescales, network companies would take steps to terminate the agreement⁵.

The main components of Connection Queue Management are:

- a) **Connection Milestone(s)**, which are also referred to as Customer Progression Milestones or simply Milestone(s), form the agreed benchmarks by which DNOs and their Customers can measure and track project progress towards a contracted connection date. Customers will be required to submit to the DNO the required evidence confirming that a Milestone has been met. Following review, the DNO will then confirm to the Customer that the DNO agrees the Milestone has been met. The Milestone will be considered met on the date on which the DNO confirms that the required evidence meets all necessary criteria and standards.
- b) **Milestone dates** – Milestones include a contracted date based on the Offer Acceptance Date, or the Offered Connection Date, if this is more than 5 years after the Offer Acceptance Date. Each date reflects the latest date by which the Customer must meet the Milestone, but Customers may meet the Milestone before that date.
- c) **Milestone Remedy Notice** – this is the process by which Customers will be informed of upcoming and/or overdue Milestone dates and the length of time permitted for remedy if a Milestone date is not met.

By using Milestones and remedy timescales, delayed projects can be identified and agreements potentially terminated to make connection capacity available for projects that are progressing in line with their Milestones. The application of Connection Queue Management in a clear and consistent way to remove delayed projects from connection queues ensures that network capacity is available for other projects that are ready to progress. These could be projects that are already in the connection queue or new connection applications.

⁵ Where a project is in the connection queue, this means the Customer has accepted the network company's connection offer, which is sometimes known by different terms, e.g. connection agreement, construction agreement etc. The term 'agreement' is used in this guide and refers to the connection offer that has been accepted by the Customer.

3 Why is a Connection Queue Management process needed?

Some areas of the distribution and transmission networks have greater limitations on capacity to connect new Customers than others and, when that capacity is fully utilised, network reinforcement may be required to create new capacity. This has both cost and time implications for connecting Customers.

In assessing any new connections, network companies need to consider any Customers that have accepted connection offers but have not yet connected. These contracted but not yet connected Customers form queues and, if they are not progressing their connections in a timely manner by achieving their Connection Milestones, it can have a negative impact on any subsequent Customers wishing to connect to the network (e.g. delays in connecting). By using agreed milestones and remedy timescales, delayed projects can be identified, and agreements can be terminated to make connection capacity available for projects that are progressing in line with agreed milestones or future connections.

4 Purpose and scope of this guide.

This guide sets out a policy framework to be adopted across distribution networks and that is aligned, where appropriate, with transmission processes (refer to CMP376⁶), enabling network companies to intervene in the connection queue where Customers have not met their Connection Milestones. In this guide, the term 'network company' is used as a generic term to cover all DNOs.

This guide explains how the Connection Queue Management process works, and network companies will clarify how they apply it to their networks. The guide includes:

- A description of the Connection Queue Management process that will apply across the distribution network,
- Flow process diagrams to set out the overall process in each of the three possible routes to connection,
- A description of each Milestone and the required evidence,
- The Milestone Remedy Notice process,
- Issues outside of a Customer's control, and
- Suggested communications with Customers during key stages of the Connection Queue Management process.

4.1 Scope.

4.1.1 Generation connections:

All DNOs have committed to applying Connection Milestones to distributed generation projects (including storage) with a capacity of 1MW or more, regardless of whether the connection requires National Energy System Operator (NESO) to assess the impact to the Transmission System. Connection Milestones will also be applied at lower thresholds where subject to regional variations (see Section 6.2) and DNOs may apply milestones below this threshold at their discretion⁷, which will be confirmed in the connection offer.

⁶ [CMP376: Inclusion of Queue Management process within the CUSC | Ofgem](#)

⁷ For clarity this is no change to Queue Management User Guide v5.0.

For the purposes of this guidance document, 'Transmission Entry Assessment' (TEA) is used to capture all circumstances – for Generation and Demand projects - where interface with NESO is initiated to assess the impact of a project on the Transmission System. For clarity, we would note that Transmission Entry Assessment is not a defined term in the Connection and Use of System Code (CUSC) and is used here to capture circumstances where a Transmission Evaluation Application and/or Transmission Impact Assessment may be used as defined in the CUSC.

This version of the guidance document will apply to all distributed **generation** (incl. storage) applications to connect to the distribution network received on or after 1 October 2025 whether the scheme is subject to a NESO TEA or not, in line with the capacity guidance given above.

For schemes not subject to a NESO TEA process and submitted prior to 1 October 2025, the previous version of the Queue Management Milestones (v5.0) will continue to apply - where this is indicated by the DNO in the connection offer - unless subsequently varied.

For any scheme that applied prior to 1 October 2025, is subject to NESO TEA and specifically is eligible for the Gate 2 To Whole Queue (G2TWQ) CMP435 process and is subsequently successful through this process securing a Gate 2 offer, then this version of the Queue Management Milestone guidance will apply from the point the Gate 2 offer is accepted.

For clarity, for schemes subject to the CMP435 G2TWQ process, this means that, if NESO makes a "Gate 2" connection offer to the DNO following conclusion of NESO's TMO4+ process, **the revised connection offer the DNO will make to the Customer will include updated Milestones in line with this document**. Any Milestone that has been confirmed as being met prior to or during the TMO4+ G2TWQ (CMP435) process will be considered to be complete and will not be reopened (e.g. if appropriate evidence has been provided during the TMO4+ process). Acceptance of the revised connection offer will include acceptance of those revised Connection Milestones that have not yet been met.

For any scheme that applied prior to 1 October 2025 and is subject to NESO TEA, but was not included in the G2TWQ CMP435 process (and will therefore need to pass through a future CMP434 window) this version of the Milestone guidance shall apply from the date of implementation (1 October 2025). For the purpose of Milestone 4 (M4), the trigger for the milestone shall be no sooner than the later of the implementation date (1 October 2025) or the Offer Acceptance date.

4.1.2 Demand connections:

The process described in this guide applies to **demand** applications to connect to the distribution network received on or after 1 October 2025. This guidance will be applied to **all** connections that have a capacity of 5MVA and above. DNOs are able to apply Milestones to smaller connections at all voltage levels at their discretion. Note that some DNOs already apply Milestones at lower voltage and capacity limits and will continue to do so on the basis of this updated approach to Connection Queue Management.

All demand applications received before 1 October 2025 are out of scope of this version of the guidance unless you and your DNO have explicitly agreed to apply the updated milestones. Unless such an agreement exists, your project will remain subject to the Queue Management User Guide v5.0⁸ as and if previously agreed with your DNO.

⁸ [ON21-WS2-P2 Updated Queue Management User Guide \(30 Jul 2021\).pdf](#)

4.2 Connections Reform and Clean Power 2030.

The existing connections process was developed and designed over 20 years ago when the energy landscape was far less complex than it is today, and the volume of projects has grown exponentially in recent years. The existing 'first come, first served' approach to connections projects means that the connections process has not kept pace with the rapid changes occurring in the energy sector. This, combined with the urgent need to meet Net Zero targets, means that a new process needs to be developed.

Given the clear and urgent need to reform the connections process, NESO launched the Connections Reform project in 2022, which introduced the concepts of windows and gates into the connections process as well as a set of criteria and capacity caps per technology type, moving to a "first ready and needed, first connected" approach. The application windows and TEA Gated process require projects to meet minimum requirements to obtain a connection offer.

To reflect these changes, Milestone 4 has been updated, meaning that, if a project does not pass through the TEA Gated process (as defined in Section 6.3.1 of this document) within 24 months from the date on which the Customer accepted the DNO's connection offer, the DNO will terminate the relevant agreement. Please note that Connections Reform only applies to generation projects that exceed the TEA thresholds. These are as defined by NESO and are currently:

- For England and Wales at or above 5MW where there are no identified fault level issues at the Grid Supply Point (GSP), otherwise at or above 1MW; and
- For Scotland at or above 200kW (50kW for Scottish Islands).

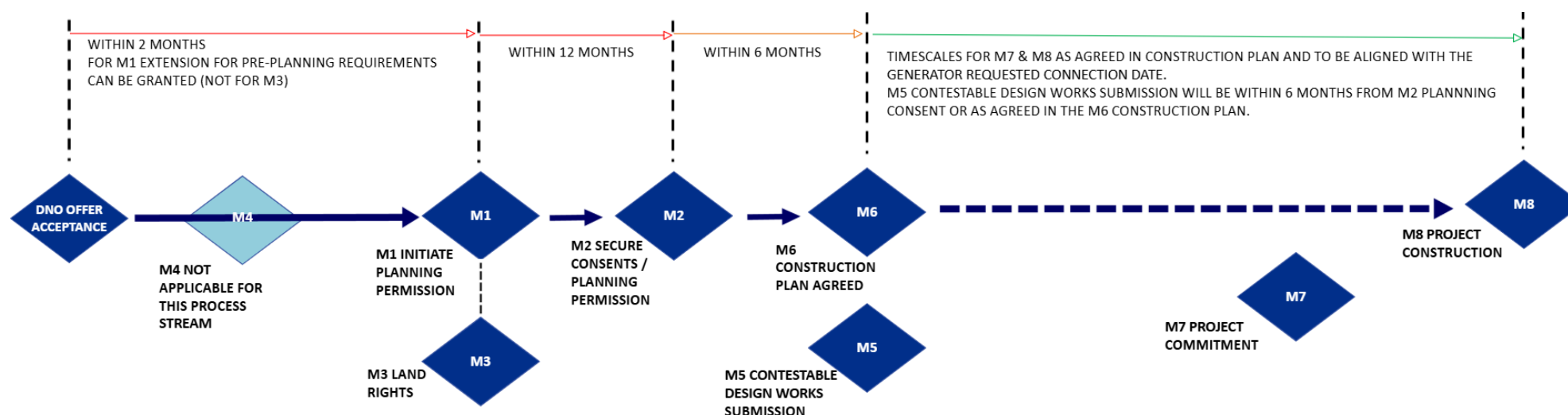
For clarity, if a Customer scheme goes through a NESO TEA process and is unsuccessful, resulting in a DNO variation to a Gate 1, Milestones will not apply (while the scheme is at Gate 1 status).

5 Connection Queue Management process summary.

The following section summarises the process for establishing Connection Milestones in scenarios where either a TEA is **not** required (i.e. the DNO is able to connect without reference to NESO) or where a TEA referral **is** required (i.e. the project will go through a TEA).

5.1 Connections where the TEA process is not required.

Figure 1 – Flow Diagram to Illustrate Queue Management Process where **no** TEA is required.

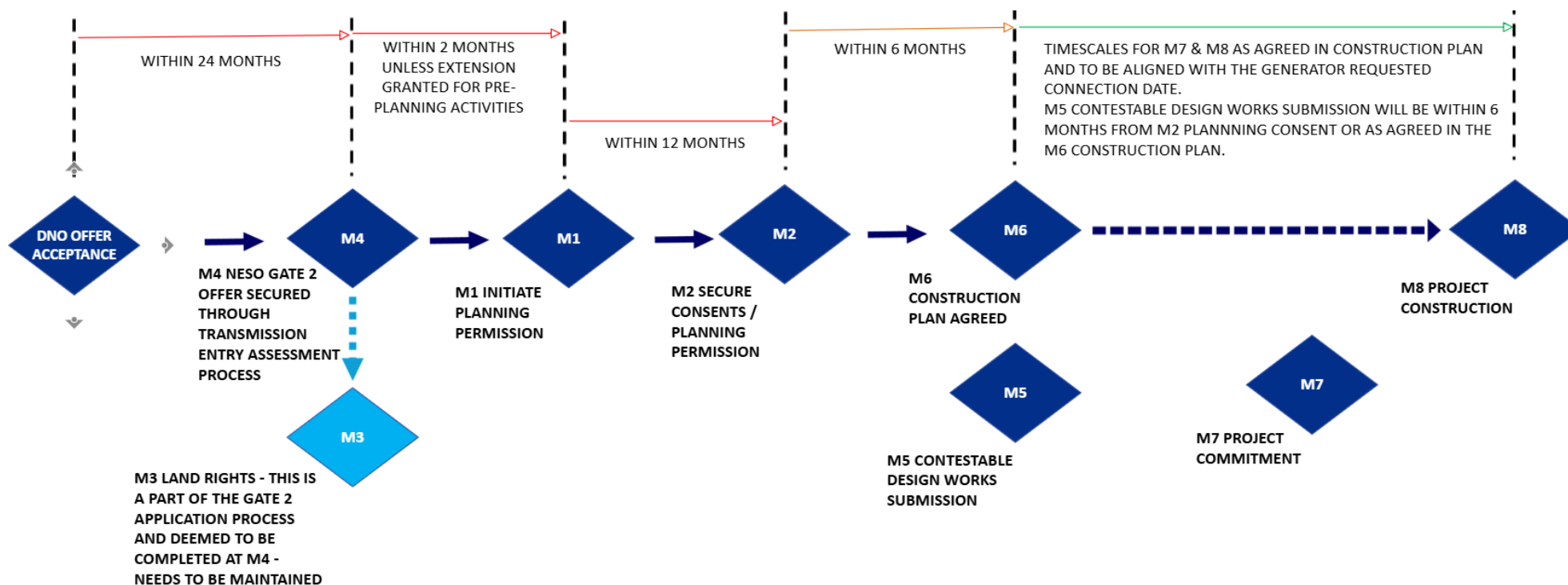


Where there is no TEA requirement M4 is not required.

Pre-Construction milestones: M1, M2, M3 and M6 (Planning, Land Rights Construction Plan) are determined by the Offer Acceptance Date or, where the Offered Connection Date is more than 5 years in the future, by working back from the Offered Connection Date.

5.2 Connections where the TEA Gated process applies

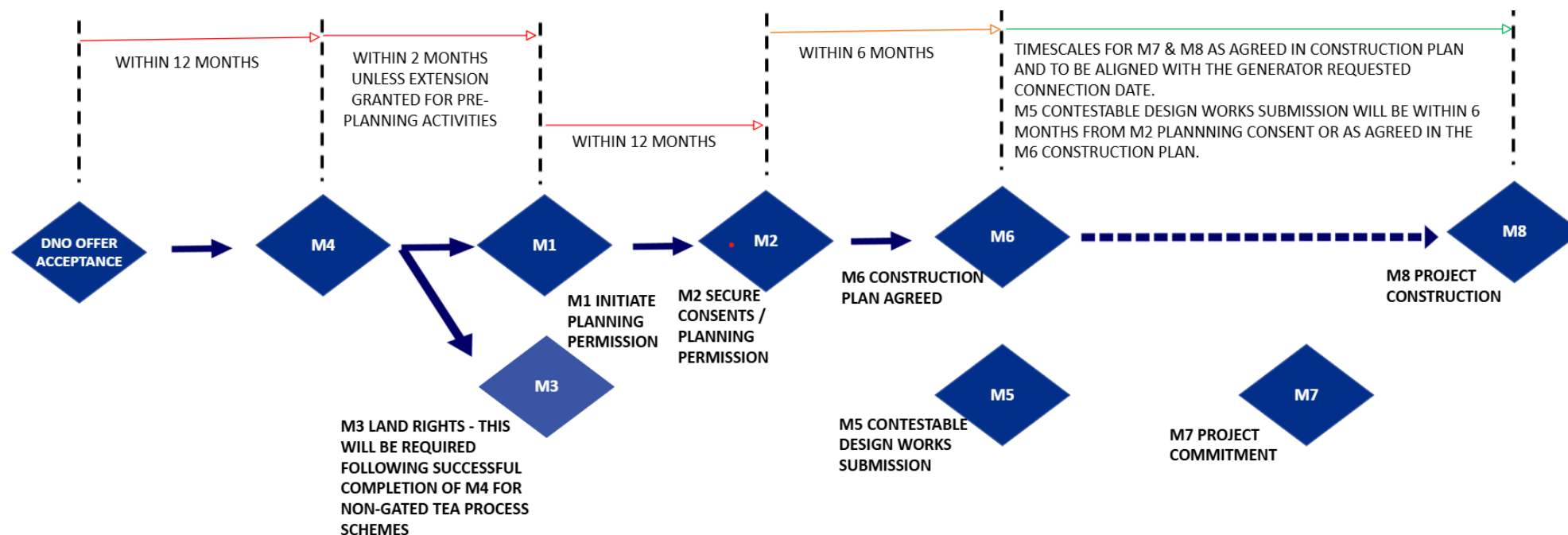
Figure 2 – Flow Diagram to illustrate the Queue Management process where a TEA is required **and** the project is subject to the Connections Reform Gated process (see 4.2).



Pre-Construction milestones: M1, M2, and M6 (Initiate Planning Permission, Secure Planning Permission and Construction Plan Achieved) are calculated from the **date on which the Customer accepts the DNO's revised connection offer** following the outcome of NESO's TEA process. Alternatively, where the Offered Connection Date is more than 5 years in future, by working back from the Offered Connection Date.

5.3 Connections where the TEA non-Gated process applies.

Figure 3 – Flow Diagram to illustrate the Queue Management process where a TEA **is** required but the project is **not** subject to the Connections Reform Gated process. This is generally applicable to larger demand connections.



Pre-Construction milestones: M1, M2, M3 and M6 (Planning, Land Rights Construction Plan) are determined by the date on which the Customer accepts the DNO's revised connection offer following the outcome of NESO's TEA non-Gated process. Alternatively, where the Offered Connection Date is more than 5 years in future, by working back from the Offered Connection Date.

6 The Connection Milestones Explained

Milestones form the basis of the Connection Queue Management process and are included in agreements to measure the progress of a project towards meeting its connection date. This allows Customers and network companies to have better visibility of a project's progression and to identify risks where projects are delayed against the Milestones. Milestones provide clear signals of when projects will be defined as delayed and may, therefore, be blocking capacity that could be used by other projects.

- Milestones represent the completion of key stages in the delivery of projects that aim to connect to electricity networks to export (or generate) electricity, to import electricity (or take supplies) or to both export and import electricity.
- Milestones are intended to be transparent and realistic, with an expectation that Customers will have undertaken relevant project development activity to assess the feasibility of projects before accepting a connection offer.
- Each Milestone has a timescale attached to it and evidence is required to confirm that the Milestone has been met.
- Once a Customer accepts the connection offer, the Customer is responsible for providing suitable evidence to demonstrate that the relevant milestones have been met within the specified timescales. Failure to provide this evidence will lead to the DNO initiating the Milestone Remedy Notice process.
- While these principles could apply to all projects, the timescales may not apply to projects requiring Development Consent Orders (DCO) due to the small number of this type of project. For projects requiring DCOs, bespoke timescales would be agreed between the parties on a case-by-case basis, but it is anticipated that timescales to secure statutory consents could increase to around 36 months

Once a Milestone is met and has been accepted by the DNO, the expectation is that this will continue to be the case without need of further evidence that the necessary conditions remain in place. Any change to the status of a completed Milestone (e.g. change in land ownership) should be raised with the DNO as soon as possible.

6.1 Connection Milestones - Timescales

The tables in Section 6.3 detail the timescales for meeting the Milestones, working **forward** from the Offer Acceptance date, or from conclusion of any TEA process that may be required in cases where the **Offered Connection Date is less than five years** from the Offer Acceptance date.

Where any **Offered Connection Date exceeds five years** from acceptance or conclusion, as above, Connection Milestone dates will be calculated working **back** from the connection date, in line with the NESO Connection Milestone process. See table below.

6.1.1 Milestone dates for connection dates greater than 5 years in future.

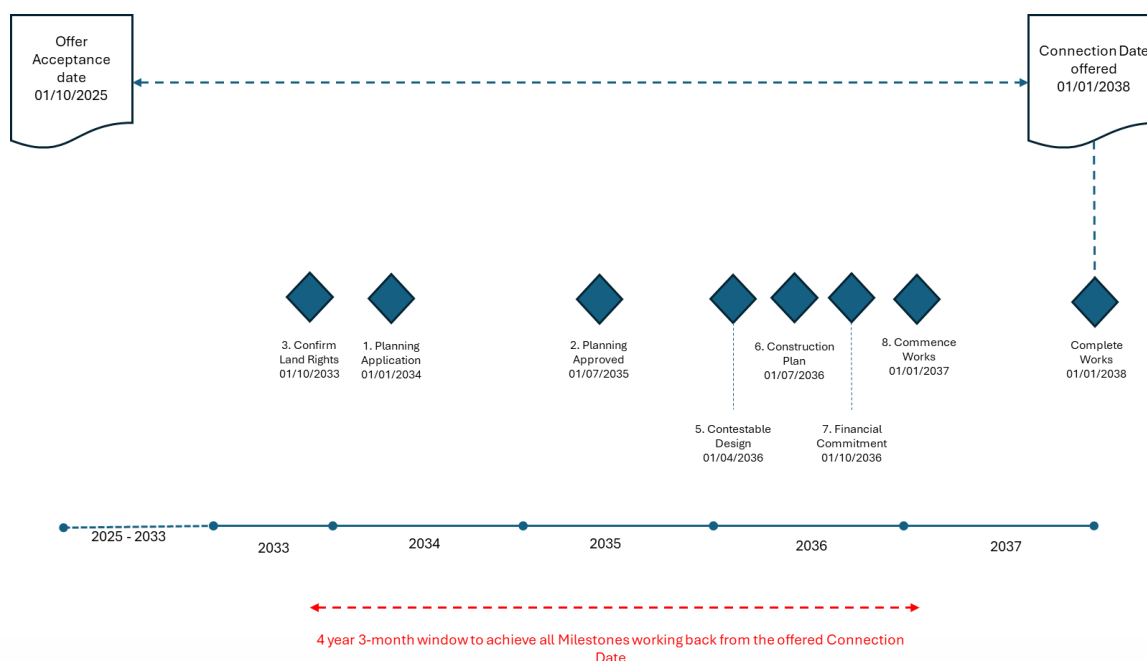
The table below sets out the Milestones where the Offered Connection Date is more than 5 years from the Offer Acceptance Date.

	Milestone Date: Calculated back from the Offered Connection Date by this period:	Example: In October 2025 the DNO makes an offer with a Connection Date of 01 st Jan 2038
M1 – Submit planning	48 months	1 Jan 2034
M2 – Achieve planning	30 months	1 July 2035
M3 – Confirm Land Rights	51 months	1 Oct 2033
M4 – DNO/NESO interface	N/A*	N/A*
M5 – Contestable Design	21 months	1 April 2036
M6 – Construction Plan	18 months	1 July 2036
M7 – Financial Commitments	15 months	1 October 2036
M8 – Commence Work	12 months	1 Jan 2037

* M4 is noted as “N/A” in the table below as the deadline for completion of this milestone is calculated as 24 months from the Offer Acceptance Date in both the forward-looking (connection dates less than five years in the future) and backward-looking scenarios (connection dates greater than 5 years in future).

The approach outlined above provides a window of 4 years and 3 months for the Customer to complete all Milestones, working back from the Offered Connection Date. This is illustrated below based on an Offer Acceptance Date (see above) of 01/10/2025.

Figure 4 – High Level Timescales of Milestones where the Offered Connection Date is more than 5 years from the Offer Acceptance Date.



6.2 Connection Milestones and Transmission Assessment.

A key factor in determining Milestones for DNO connections is whether a TEA is required. DNOs will identify and clarify with the Customer if a TEA is required during the application and offer process. At the time of publication, thresholds for DNO connections requiring a TEA are as follows (but please note that thresholds will be applied consistently with the provisions of the CUSC, which may change from time to time):

Generation Connections

- Generation schemes with a capacity equal to or greater than 5MW in England and Wales or equal to or greater than 200 kVA in Scotland (or equal to or greater than 50kVA on Scottish Islands); and
- In England and Wales, if there are fault level issues at the GSP⁹ then a TEA will be required for projects with a capacity equal to or greater than 1MW. Contact your DNO to confirm whether this will apply to your connection.

Demand Connections

- Relevant demand¹⁰ connections where the DNO considers the connection will need a NESO assessment.

The three possible processes and how the Pre-Construction Milestones (see Section 6.3.2) are determined, is summarised in the table below:

Process	M4 – Complete TEA process	M1 – Initiate Planning Permission	M2 – Secure Planning Permission	M3 – Secure Land Rights	M6 – Establish Construction Plan
TEA Gated process	Customer must meet NESO Gated Conditions and sign the DNO's associated Gate 2 variation within 24 months of the date on which the Customer accepted the DNO's connection offer. For clarity, this is the conclusion of the NESO Gated TEA process and you will have needed to submit your Readiness Declaration to the DNO in sufficient time to successfully complete the review and sign the associated Gate 2 offer	M4 +2 months*	M1 +12 months*	Completed during the Gated process**	M2 +6 months

⁹ Where the fault level headroom is below 1KA at the GSP as referenced on NESO's Appendix G. Note that this level may change, please check with your DNO at application stage.

¹⁰ Currently, demand connections are assessed on a case-by-case basis and, where the DNOs and/or NESO deem that the connection could have an impact on the Transmission network, a (non-gated) TEA will be required.

Process	M4 – Complete TEA process	M1 – Initiate Planning Permission	M2 – Secure Planning Permission	M3 – Secure Land Rights	M6 – Establish Construction Plan
TEA non-Gated process	Customer must meet NESO Modification Conditions, including placing any required securities, within 12 months from the date on which the Customer accepted the DNO's connection offer.	M4 +2 months*	M1 +12 months*	M4 +2 months	M2 +6 months
No TEA required	N/A	Offer Acceptance +2 months*	M1 +12 months*	Offer Acceptance +2 months	M2 +6 months

* Subject to any legislative or planning authority requirements (see 6.3.1).

** Subject to Evidence provided for Gated process.

Note that all dates in the table above are where the Offered Connection Date is within the next 5 years. For Offered Connection Dates greater than 5 years the Milestone date will be as per 6.1.1.

6.3 Connection Milestones – detailed description.

Due to the impact of M4 on other Milestones (see previous section) Milestone 4 is presented first.

6.3.1 Milestone 4 (M4) – NESO Interface

Key point: This Milestone will only apply where NESO requires a TEA to be carried out and has to provide the DNO with consent to connect. The TEA will confirm if transmission works or operational restrictions are required for the DNO connection to be provided and will secure rights for use of the Transmission System (this is obligatory for embedded generators above a certain size). The intent of this Milestone is to ensure that the Customer is progressing their project through the connections process in an appropriate timeframe. The processes by which relevant works impacting the transmission network are normally assessed are set out in the CUSC.

- **TEA Gated** process: Where the DNO's connection offer is subject to the outcome of NESO's **Gated** process, M4 is the date by which the DNO's Customer must agree in writing to any conditions determined by the NESO following the TEA.
- **TEA non-Gated** process: Where the DNO's connection offer is subject to the outcome of a TEA but is not subject to NESO's Gated process, M4 is the date by which the DNO's Customer must agree in writing to any conditions determined by the NESO following the TEA.
- **Non-TEA Process**: M4 is not applicable where the DNO's connection offer is not subject to a TEA. In this case, the first applicable Milestones will be M1 and M3 which will have a deadline of two months from acceptance of the DNO's connection offer.

DNO connection is subject to:	Measured from	Timescale	Evidence ¹¹
TEA Gated process	Date of acceptance of the DNO's connection offer.	24 months	Agreement in writing to the outcome of the NESO TEA process such that the NESO Gate 2 Offer has been or can be accepted within its validity period.
TEA non-Gated process	Date of acceptance of the DNO's connection offer.	12 months	Agreement in writing to the outcome of the NESO TEA process
No TEA required	N/A	N/A	N/A

¹¹ More information on the evidence required to meet the Gate 2 process can be found in the NESO Gate 2 Methodology

6.3.2 Pre-Construction Milestones - Milestones 1 to 3 and Milestone 6

Pre-Construction Milestones for a distribution connection (meaning the Milestones that must be completed before the actual construction work can begin on a connection) are:

- Milestone 1 (M1): Initiate planning and consents.
- Milestone 2 (M2): Securing planning permission.
- Milestone 3 (M3): Secure Land Rights for the site.
- Milestone 6 (M6): Agree a Construction Plan with the DNO.

The dates for M1, M2, M3 and M6 are determined by the need for a TEA (i.e. the inclusion of M4), and / or any evidenced pre-planning requirements from the planning authority.

- M4 applies if a TEA is required and, where this is the case, becomes the initial Milestone. The Pre-Construction Milestone dates are only set **after** M4 has been met and the TEA process is concluded.
- If pre-planning requirements are evidenced by the Customer, M1 and (by default) M2 and M6 are extended by at least 12 months (note that this does not impact M3). See Section 6.3.3.
- If a TEA is required and there are evidenced pre-planning requirements, then the additional time allowed to meet Milestones M1, M2 and M6 is applied after M4 Milestone is met.

It is important to note the implication of not meeting Pre-Construction Milestones, as detailed in Section 8.

6.3.3 Milestone 1 (M1) - Initiated statutory consents including Planning Permission

Key point: The Customer must begin the process of seeking statutory consents - including making a formal application for Planning Permission for the project - within the timescales detailed below and be able to provide the required evidence. Planning approval may take considerable time, and the Customer is expected to initiate early stages of the planning process prior to making its application to the DNO.

Pre-Planning requirements.

Planning Authorities may place pre-planning requirements on the Customer (i.e. work that must be completed prior to submitting the planning application). Examples include:

- An Environmental Impact Assessment (EIA) and/or non-EIA environmental or ecological studies.
- Specialist reports, such as Landscape and Visual Impact Assessments, Ecological Phase 1 Studies, and Traffic Impact Assessments

Customers are expected to evidence any pre-planning requirements as soon as possible, and certainly no later than the point from which M1 is measured (see table below). For clarity, the Customer is expected to present to the DNO evidence that the Customer has received pre-planning requirements from the Planning Authority. DNOs will make reasonable adjustments to the Milestone date to incorporate pre-planning requirements (normally 12 months, but longer if appropriate).

Where there are no pre-planning requirements prior to making a formal application for Planning Permission, M1 is set at 2 months after the relevant date from which it is measured (see table below).

DNO connection is subject to:	Measured from	Timescale	Evidence
No TEA required	Date of acceptance of the DNO's connection offer	Where no additional Pre-Planning Requirements: 2 months. Where additional Pre-Planning Requirements evidenced: 12 months or as agreed with DNO.	Planning Application reference number, viewable on LPA website. Customers may supply copies of planning approval documentation.
TEA Gated process	Date of the successful completion of M4		
TEA non-Gated process	Date of the successful completion of M4		

Note that all dates in the table above are where the Offered Connection Date is within the next 5 years. For Offered Connection Dates greater than 5 years the Milestone date will be as per 6.1.1.

The following are examples of steps the Customer may take prior to making a formal planning application in order to ensure the requirements of M1 are met (e.g. prior to acceptance of the DNO's connection offer). For clarity, please note that these steps alone are **not** sufficient to meet the evidence requirements for this Milestone.

- Pre-application advice: Not binding, and the full Planning Application may not be approved.
- Planning Performance Agreement. Semi-legal agreement between Local Planning Authority (LPA) and Applicant. Will include expected date for planning submission to be made. See here: [good-practice-advice-and--fcb.pdf](#)
- Outline Planning. E.g. Outline planning for 100 houses but no details on the development. Issued with Reserved Matters. See here: [Outline Planning Permission](#)

6.3.4 Milestone 2 (M2) – Secured statutory consents including Planning Permission

Key point: The Customer must have secured statutory consents, including Planning Permission for the project within the timescales detailed below and be able to provide the required evidence. The deadline for this Milestone is measured from the date of completion of M1. However, Customers may initiate the required processes in order to meet M1 before the Offer Acceptance Date, such that M2 may be completed earlier.

DNO connection is subject to:	Measured from	Timescale	Evidence
No TEA required TEA Gated process TEA Non-Gated process	Completion of M1 milestone	12 Months	Customer to confirm that planning consent has been secured with relevant planning notice reference. Approved Planning Notice viewable on LPA website.

Note that all dates in the table above are where the Offered Connection Date is within the next 5 years. For Offered Connection Dates greater than 5 years the Milestone date will be as per 6.1.1.

6.3.5 Milestone 3 (M3) – Land Rights

Key point: The Customer must have secured the required Land Rights to enable the construction of the project.

DNO connection is subject to:	Measured from	Timescale	Evidence
No TEA required	Date of acceptance of the DNO's connection offer	2 months	Customer will provide documentation to demonstrate that, with respect to the land on which the connection or substation is situated, it: • Is the owner or occupier of that land; or • Has entered into an agreement to lease the land; or • Has an option to purchase or to lease the land, or • Has entered into an exclusivity agreement in relation to the land.
TEA Gated process	If not already secured, then date of completion of M4	n/a	This Milestone is deemed to be met when the Gated process is completed following a Land Readiness application. This is evidenced by acceptance of the revised connection offer issued following a successful Gate 2 offer from NESO. If a DCO process is being followed, then the evidence requirements as per TEA non-Gated process below apply.
TEA non-Gated process	Date of completion of M4	2 months	Customer will provide documentation to demonstrate that, with respect to the land on which the connection or substation is situated, it: • Is the owner or occupier of that land; or • Has entered into an agreement to lease the land; or • Has an option to purchase or to lease the land.

The Customer may be the owner/occupier of the land or have the necessary agreement from the owner/occupier (e.g. an Independent Connection Provider (ICP) or Independent Distribution Network Operator (IDNO) may secure the land rights from an owner or occupier).

Note that all dates in the table above are where the Offered Connection Date is within the next 5 years. For offered connection dates greater than 5 years the Milestone Date will be as per 6.1.1.

6.3.6 Milestone 5 (M5) – Contestable Design Works Submission (applicable to distribution connections)

Milestones M5 and M6 are presented sequentially within this guidance document. However, it is understood that, in some cases of integrated and/or iterative project design processes, the decision to appoint an ICP or IDNO to undertake the Contestable Design Works will not occur until a Construction Plan is in place. We would note, therefore, that the sequence in which these Milestones will be met may vary depending on the project. The Milestone M5 (Contestable Design Submission) date will be set at either 6 months after Milestone M2 is met or the date that is agreed as part of the Milestone M6 Construction Plan submission. Please discuss with your DNO when planning has been approved.

Key point: This Milestone will apply where a Customer has not accepted the DNO's offer to carry out the contestable work in order to provide the connection. In such circumstances, the Customer will be required to provide evidence that the Customer's ICP has submitted a design for contestable works to the DNO. Alternatively, the Customer's ICP is required to provide notification to the DNO to confirm where it has self-approved its own design.

DNO connection is subject to:	Measured from	Timescale	Evidence
No TEA required	Date of completion of M2	6 months or as agreed with the DNO and included in the M6 Construction Plan	Submitted contestable design submission (full design submission unless otherwise agreed with the DNO). Where the DNO agrees to accept partial or phased design submissions (e.g. first submitted design) binding dates for submission of an approved design must be agreed as part of M6.
TEA Gated process			
TEA non-Gated process			

Note that all dates in the table above are where the Offered Connection Date is within the next 5 years. For Offered Connection Dates greater than 5 years the Milestone date will be as per 6.1.1.

6.3.7 Milestone 6 (M6) – Provision and agreement of Construction Plan

Key point: The Customer must agree the Construction Plan (and/or ICP programme of works) with the DNO in a way that sufficiently demonstrates how the Customer will achieve the connection date. The required timescale for this Milestone is measured from Planning Permission being granted (M2) and demonstrates that the Customer is ready to proceed with the project. The Customer is encouraged to engage with the DNO early and ahead of the Milestone deadline in order to develop the Construction Plan. This will allow the connection to be integrated into the DNO's wider construction programme.

The timing of the construction start date is important in demonstrating that the project is progressing. In some cases, this date could occur a considerable time after the agreement of the Construction Plan (for example, the work may be contingent on the completion of network reinforcement) but, in most cases, progress would be expected soon after the Construction Plan is agreed. If the proposed construction start date is more than 12 months after M6, then further explanation should be sought from the Customer and either additional evidence of project progression sought or an explanation for the delay provided.

As a minimum, the Construction Plan should include dates for the construction start, construction completion, and completion of Milestone 7 (Project Commitment). Interim construction milestones may also be required by the DNO depending on the nature, extent and duration of the project works so that progress can be demonstrated. Where the Customer's project is being connected in phases, the Construction Plan should show what capacity is required and when. Where the DNO agrees to accept a partial design submission, the dates for later submissions should be agreed as part of M6. The Construction Plan should include the following key information where applicable:

- Plant order placement dates.
- ICP appointment.
- Design submission dates (including protection and control schemes).
- Construction commencement and completion dates (including critical path construction items).
- Commissioning dates.
- G99 compliance statement submission.
- Details of any phased increases of capacity required (see Section 7.2)
- Any other relevant milestones specific to the project.

DNO connection is subject to:	Measured from	Timescale	Evidence
No TEA required TEA Gated process TEA non-Gated process	Date of completion of M2	6 months	Customer's programme of works (and/or ICP programme of works) that demonstrates when project construction will commence and complete and how the project will be ready for the connection date: • The programme may include interim construction milestones to demonstrate progress towards construction completion. (Including partial design submissions) • Additional evidence may be required to demonstrate sufficient project progression if the construction start date is more than 12 months after agreement of the construction plan.

Note that all dates in the table above are where the Offered Connection Date is within the next 5 years. For Offered Connection Dates greater than 5 years the Milestone date will be as per 6.1.1.

6.3.8 Milestone 7 (M7) – Project Commitment

Key point: This Milestone demonstrates that the project has the necessary commitment and/or backing for it to proceed. In order to meet the Milestone, the Customer must provide evidence as listed in the table below:

DNO connection is subject to:	Measured from	Timescale	Evidence
No TEA required TEA Gated process TEA non-Gated process	As agreed in the Construction Plan (at M6)	As agreed with the DNO	Evidence where the DNO is not completing contestable works: • Binding contract for the supply and installation of the main plant equipment including, for example, substations or generation equipment. Evidence where the DNO is completing contestable works: • Full or staged payment made to the DNO totalling at least 50% of the overall payment due to the DNO. Alternatively, and where applicable, these are other acceptable forms of financial commitment: • the Customer has secured a suitable Government Contract such as CfD or CM; or • Board paper evidencing the Final Investment Decision (FID); or • Subsidy award.

Note that all dates in the table above are where the Offered Connection Date is within the next 5 years. For Offered Connection Dates greater than 5 years the Milestone date will be as per 6.1.1.

Milestone Dates for Project Commitment.

Projects may vary with regard to when the Customer financially commits to the project. This Milestone is intended to evidence that the Customer is fully committed to financing the project regardless of the delivery model (e.g. DNO full works, ICP build with DNO adopt, or IDNO build). DNOs may also offer staged payments.

Milestone M7 requires evidence of financial commitment by the Customer (where an ICP or IDNO is building the connection), or that at least 50% of full contract price is paid (where the DNO is completing all of the works).

1. Where DNO completing contestable works: M7 is met where the Customer accepts the DNO's connection offer to carry out both the contestable and the non-contestable work and pays the contract price in full on acceptance.
2. Where DNO completing contestable works and staged payment schedule agreed: Where the Customer accepts the DNO's offer to carry out both the contestable and the non-contestable work, which includes agreement to pay the contract price on a staged payment basis, Milestone M7 is the date on which the

Customer has paid at least 50% of the contract price in accordance with the agreed schedule of staged payments.

3. Where DNO completing non-contestable works only: M7 is met where the Customer accepts the DNO's connection offer to carry out the non-contestable works only, pays the contract price in full on acceptance and provides evidence of sufficient financial commitment to completing the contestable work (e.g. evidence the Customer has placed an order for the contestable connection assets (see table above)). This Milestone date would be 6 months after Milestone M5 (contestable design completed) is met or as reflected in the Construction Plan.

6.3.9 Milestone 8 (M8) – Project Construction

Key point: The Milestones associated with the Project Construction stage shall incorporate both the commencement of substantive works and the completion of all Customer works. M8 may, therefore, be a multi-stage Milestone and will be measured against both an agreed construction start and completion date taken from the Construction Plan. Other interim construction milestones may be agreed through the Construction Plan to demonstrate that the project is progressing in line with the planned completion date.

Delays against the construction start, interim milestones or completion dates could lead to the Milestone not being met and termination of the agreement if the timescales set out in the Milestone Remedy Notice are exceeded. DNOs will look to allow some flexibility in those timescales through the construction phase where this is reasonably possible. For example, if interim construction Milestones have been achieved and construction is progressing, but the construction completion date has been delayed, a variation may be requested by the Customer to extend the Milestone. The DNO has discretion to decide whether to accept a proposed amendment.

DNO connection is subject to:	Measured from	Timescale	Evidence
No TEA required TEA Gated process TEA non-Gated process	Construction Plan (M6)	Commence construction in line with date agreed in the Construction Plan (Milestone M6); and Delivery and completion of the Customer works in accordance with the agreed Construction Plan, including any interim construction milestones and the completion date.	Commencement of substantive works at the customer's project site. Additionally, the customer must maintain clear progress as per the construction plan agreed with the Network Company by achieving any additional interim target dates, up to and including the completion of all customer works

Note that all dates in the table above are where the Offered Connection Date is within the next 5 years. For Offered Connection Dates greater than 5 years the Milestone date will be as per 6.1.1.

Change to site boundaries.

Applications to connect to the DNO's distribution network normally require the Customer to submit to the DNO a plan whereby the site on which the connection to be made is defined, for example, with a Red Line Boundary (RLB). The original RLB applied for should reflect the RLB at planning (M1 and M2), M5 (Contestable design

submission) and M6 (Construction Plan). Changes to the RLB at any point after the application is made may be allowable without impacting the application's status, but only where confirmed as allowable by the DNO. Please refer to the ENA's Allowable Changes document for further information regarding allowable and disallowable changes. The RLB should remain unchanged unless the DNO has confirmed that any changes proposed by the Customer are allowable.

If the Customer submits an RLB directly to NESO as part of the Gated process, they must also provide a copy to the DNO. This allows the DNO to verify whether the RLB submitted to NESO matches the one originally submitted with the Customer's application. Any discrepancies will be assessed to determine whether they constitute allowable or disallowable changes.

7 Non-Firm and Phased Capacity Connections

In recent years, there has been an emerging and increasing trend of connection offers allowing projects to connect to the distribution network on the basis of non-firm capacity or capacity that will be delivered in phases in line with agreed demand profiles. This section provides further context on the Connection Queue Management approach that will be taken in respect of those forms of connection.

7.1 Technical Limits or Curtailable Connections

Where projects are able to proceed in a timely and efficient manner based on agreed constraints while any necessary reinforcement work is undertaken, connection applications may be progressed on a non-firm basis. This will have the effect of allowing eligible projects to obtain an earlier connection date than would be possible if they had to await completion of the required reinforcement. Such constraints may include the following:

- **Technical Limits:** allowing new generation connections to be made on a non-firm basis prior to the completion of necessary reinforcement works and where a maximum allowable power flow through a GSP applies.
- **Curtailable Connections:** allowing new generation connections to be made on a non-firm basis prior to the completion of necessary reinforcement works and where, under certain network conditions, the import and/or export capacity for a connection may be reduced to ensure that network power flows do not exceed network limits.

Where a Customer has accepted a connection offer on the basis of Technical Limits or a Curtailable Connection, the applicable Milestones will be calculated based on the earliest delivery date for the non-firm connection (i.e. the Offer Acceptance Date and/or connection date for the non-firm connection will be used as the basis for the applicable Milestones, irrespective of any future transition to a firm connection). Where further development is required in order for the project to progress on a firm/non-curtailable capacity basis, DNOs may require separate Milestones to be set.

This approach ensures that, where Customers agree to progress on a non-firm basis, they remain subject to fair Milestones and such offers do not become a means by which capacity is blocked that would otherwise be available to more efficient and/or timely projects.

7.2 Phased Capacity Sites

Where the expected electricity usage of a project is forecast to grow over an extended period and, therefore, has a requirement for capacity to increase over time, DNOs may make a connection offer on the basis of a Phased Capacity or staged delivery.

This allows some developments (particularly larger developments) to connect to the distribution network and grow on a managed basis, with sufficient assurance that capacity will be available for anticipated future demand over an agreed period.

Where a Customer has applied for or accepted a connection offer based on a Phased Capacity, the DNO may include interim Milestones to cover phases to be delivered after the initial phase (which will be regarded as the development required to fulfil the initial capacity requirement). For clarity, all earlier Milestones will be based on the first phase of works (i.e. the initial phase). If a Customer does not meet the interim Milestones for later phases, the DNO may initiate a variation to the agreement to reduce the total capacity of the site.

8 Delays within the Customer's Control/Milestone Remedy Notice Period

Where a delay to a project has arisen through the actions (or inaction) of the Customer, the DNO will allow the Customer some additional time to rectify the issue. This time is known as the Milestone Remedy Notice Period.

Milestone Remedy Notice Periods:

- Each Milestone will be subject to a Milestone Remedy Notice Period of 60 calendar days.

Milestone Remedy Notice Period Process:

- An accepted connection offer will be classed as "Eligible for Termination" and, therefore, subject to the Milestone Remedy Notice Period (transitioning from "On Track") where:
 - The Customer has not provided to the DNO the required evidence that a Milestone has been met; or
 - The evidence provided is considered by the DNO to be insufficient; and
- In both cases, the DNO has not agreed there is an exceptional issue affecting the progression of the project (see Section 10).

If the above applies, then the DNO will commence the termination process as follows:

1. The DNO will first issue to the Customer a Milestone Remedy Period Notice notifying the Customer that the project is classed as "Eligible for Termination" and stating that the Customer must, within the Milestone Remedy Notice Period, either provide evidence that the Milestone has already been met or provide the required evidence to meet the missed Milestone.
2. If the Milestone has not been met by the end of the Milestone Remedy Notice Period, then:
 - a. For the Pre-Construction Milestones (Milestones 1 to 4 and Milestone 6), the DNO will give notice to the Customer of its intention to terminate the agreement.
 - b. For the Construction Milestones (Milestones 5, 7 and 8), the DNO will consider whether it is appropriate to exercise its right to terminate as provided for in the agreement or may agree revised Milestone dates.

Please note - the Customer should notify the DNO as soon as possible if the Customer experiences a delay outside of their control during the Milestone Remedy Notice Period.

Where the Customer provides evidence that a milestone was not met due to events outside the Customer's control, the DNO may, at its discretion, initiate a variation to the agreement and agree revised Milestone dates. In such circumstances, the full Milestone Remedy Notice Period would apply in the event that the Customer were to not meet the Milestone again.

9 Consequences of Connection Queue Management

The application of Connection Queue Management means that there may be consequences for slow-moving projects. For projects where the Milestone Remedy Notice Period has expired and the Customer has not provided the required evidence that a Milestone has been met, the DNO may terminate the agreement. Customers would lose their place in any queue and may incur cancellation charges and/or securities charges where applicable. The Customer will need to make a new connection application, if the Customer wishes to do so. Such applications will be assessed based on the network conditions at the time of the new application and not on those that prevailed at the time of the previous application (i.e. new applications will be assessed based on updated network capacity conditions, including any updated reinforcement requirements). Additional costs in the form of reinforcement costs and/or increased securities and liabilities might then apply. If the Customer accepts the connection offer associated with a new application, the Customer will join the queue based on the new connection offer (i.e. they will not retain their original queue position).

As a result of network capacity being made available, other connections may be able to progress more quickly and may cease to be dependent on reinforcement work. Overall, the impact of Connection Queue Management will be that projects that are able to adhere to Milestones will be prioritised, leading to less unnecessary congestion in the connections queue and to reduced lead times/connection dates for projects that are ready to progress. This provides a further incentive on projects to meet their Milestones and ensures more effective use of available capacity.

10 Issues outside a Customer's control

The Connection Queue Management process recognises that there may be a small number of exceptional issues that Customers cannot control and which may lead to project delays. Delays occurring because of such issues may not trigger the Milestone Remedy Notice Period, provided that the Customer engages with its DNO and, acting in good faith, is able to evidence the issue. Examples of such exceptional issues include, but are not limited to:

- Force Majeure: Force Majeure is a provision in a contract that excuses a party in circumstances where performing its contractual obligations becomes impossible or impracticable due to an event or effect that the parties could not have anticipated or controlled¹²;
- Planning decisions delayed by planning authorities: Where a Customer has made a planning application (i.e. Milestone M1 is met) but the planning authority has not made a decision.
- Planning appeals and third-party challenges: Where a planning decision by the planning authority is challenged through a formal appeal process by the Customer or a third party to that decision.
- Where a relevant authority places an obligation on the project, which could cause the Milestone/Remedy Notice Period timescales to be exceeded and change the project status e.g. Pre-Planning Requirements.
- Any delay which is caused by a DNO (e.g. the Customer/ICP is awaiting a required input from the DNO).

Where a project experiences delays due to reason outside of a Customer's reasonable control, the Customer must:

- Discuss the specifics of the delay with the DNO at the earliest opportunity; and

¹² Definitions are in the National Terms of Connection (<http://www.connectionterms.org.uk/>) or in the Connection and Use of System Code (<https://www.nationalgrideso.com/codes/connection-and-use-system-code-cusc/>)

- Provide reasonable evidence to justify the specific delay.

Where the Customer provides evidence that the Milestone was not met due to events outside its control, the DNO can, at its discretion, issue a variation to the Milestone date(s). In such circumstances, the full Milestone Remedy Notice Period of 60 calendar days would apply in the event that the Customer were to not meet the milestone again.

11 Challenge process

Customers that wish to challenge a DNO's decision to terminate an agreement and to release connection capacity can do so under each DNO's complaints procedure. This would require the following steps to be taken.

- Initial challenge with the DNO: Highlighting justifiable reasons for review of the decision.
- Escalation: The DNO would undertake a review.
- Further escalation in line with the DNO's existing procedures.

Ofgem has the power to determine the outcomes of disputes between Electricity Distributors and Customers (both commercial and domestic) in certain circumstances. More information on Ofgem's determination powers, and how to refer a determination to Ofgem, can be found in Ofgem's guidance¹³.

12 Communication associated with Connection Queue Management

DNOs' communications to Customers regarding the Connection Milestone Management process may vary but should include the information below.

- Queue Management information in connection offers:
 - Information on each Milestone, including required timescales and evidence.
- A brief explanation of the project status categories.
- Link to further information on ENA website.

Milestone Remedy Notice, if triggered

- Notification of a change in project status to "Eligible for Termination".

DNOs may also develop further monitoring and communications over time. Customers are responsible for ensuring that they progress projects against the Milestones and providing evidence that Milestones have been met. DNOs will monitor Milestones for all projects in a connection queue. Where a project does not meet a Milestone, the DNO will inform the Customer so that the Customer is aware that the Milestone Remedy Notice Period process has been triggered.

¹³ <https://www.ofgem.gov.uk/ofgem-publications/38164/determinationsguidanceaug2012.pdf>

13 Definitions

Term	Definition
CMP	Code Modification Proposal.
Connection Milestones or Milestones	Specific target deliverables to evidence progress of a project's construction
Contestable Design Works	The design works for the Contestable Element of the extension asset required for a customer to connect to the electrical network, where not undertaken by the DNO. The Competition in Connections (CiC) process allows for an Independent Connections Provider (ICP) to prepare and approve (either via the DNO or self-certified) the design for the works, ahead of them being installed and subsequently adopted by the DNO.
Curtailable Connections	Non-firm access arrangement that allows a Customer to connect to the distribution network whilst agreeing to potential restrictions on the connection's use at certain times.
Customer	A person who has applied to the relevant DNO for the provision of a new connection or a modification to an existing connection to that DNO's distribution network.
DESNZ	Department for Energy Security and Net Zero
DNO	Distribution Network Operator
EIA	Environmental Impact Assessment
Gate 1	Projects that are deemed not to meet the Gate 2 Readiness or Strategic Alignment Criteria will be issued a Gate 1 offer. A Gate 1 offer will include an indicative connection date and indicative connection location.
Gate 2	Gate 2 is an evidence-based approach that ensures projects are assessed fairly and consistently against the NESO Gate 2 Methodology and strategic energy plans, including the Clean Power 2030 Action Plan. This process enables NESO to determine which projects are ready to connect and align with the UK's long-term energy needs. If a project meets the Gate 2 criteria, the Customer will receive a Gate 2 offer which includes the connection date, location and scope of works required for the connection and the associated transmission costs.
IDNO	Independent Distribution Network Operator
Land Readiness	The option for securing Gate 2 Readiness Criteria based on having at least an option agreement to lease or own the land required for the site
MW/MVA	Megawatts / Megavolt-amperes
Milestone Remedy Notice	The notice issued when a Milestone has passed its Milestone date and the Customer has not provided evidence that the Milestone has been met.
Milestone Remedy Notice Period	60 calendar days

Term	Definition
NESO	National Energy System Operator
Offer Acceptance Date	The latter of the date on which the Customer accepts the DNO's connection offer or, if a TEA is required (Gated or non-Gated), the date on which the Customer accepts the Gate 2 connection offer.
Offered Connection Date	The connection date offered by the DNO in the revised connection offer following any TEA (if applicable).
Ofgem	Office of Gas and Electricity Markets.
Technical Limits	Operational constraints, agreed by NESO), Transmission Network Operators (TNOs), and Distribution Network Operators (DNOs), that dictate power flow limits at Grid Supply Points (GSPs).
TEA	Transmission Entry Assessment
TEA Gated process	NESO's process for connections that require a TEA, including Gate 2 requirements.
TEA Non-Gated process	NESO's process for connections that require a TEA but do not include Gate 2 requirements.



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